SBDAGF Practitioner Checklist

A Step-by-Step Guide for Designers Applying the Small Business Digital Accessibility and Growth Framework

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How to Use This Checklist

This checklist guides a UX practitioner through a complete SBDAGF engagement — from client intake through delivery and measurement. Follow phases sequentially. Each phase must be completed before proceeding to the next.

Estimated timeline: 4–8 weeks for a standard small-business engagement.

Required tools: Figma (with Make); Lovable; Cursor; Claude Design; axe DevTools, Maze or equivalent usability platform, analytics access (if possible).

Skill level: Mid-level UX designer or trained SBDC advisor following the SBDAGF curriculum.

Phase 0: Client Intake and Scoping (Day 1–3)

Business Context

- [ ] Identify business type (service, e-commerce, local retail, product, hiring/jobs, SaaS)
- [ ] Document business location (rural / suburban / urban; underserved community: yes / no)
- [ ] Record current revenue and primary revenue channel (online vs. offline)
- [ ] Identify target customer demographic (age range, digital literacy level, devices used)
- [ ] Ask: "What does a successful customer interaction look like?" — document in their words
- [ ] Ask: "Where do you lose customers today?" — document in their words
- [ ] Confirm: Does the business have an existing website/app? (Y/N)
- [ ] Confirm: Does the business currently meet ADA/WCAG requirements? (almost certainly no)

Engagement Boundaries

- ☐ Define scope: which user flow(s) will be optimized (max 2-3 per engagement)
- ☐ Define success metric: what number must improve for the engagement to succeed
- ☐ Define timeline: start date, checkpoint dates, delivery date
- ☐ Assign decision ownership using the SBDAGF model:
    - UX trade-offs → Practitioner (you)
    - Business priorities → Business owner
    - Technical approach → AI platform / developer
    - Success measurement → Analytics / data

Deliverables Agreement

- ☐ Client understands they will receive an accessibility-compliant design specification, tested prototype, implementation guide

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Phase 1: Research and Diagnosis (Week 1)

Quantitative Diagnosis

- ☐ Install or access analytics (Google Analytics, Hotjar, or platform-native analytics)
- ☐ Map the complete user funnel: landing → engagement → conversion → retention
- ☐ Document drop-off rate at each step (% of users lost)
- ☐ Identify the single highest-impact drop-off point (largest % lost × closest to revenue)
- ☐ Check: Are mobile drop-offs higher than desktop? (common in rural audiences)
- ☐ Check: Are new-user drop-offs higher than returning users?
- ☐ Record baseline metrics:
    - Current conversion rate: ____%
    - Current each task completion time: ____ seconds
    - Current bounce rate: ____%
    - Current UMUX-Lite score (if measurable): ____/100

Qualitative Diagnosis

- ☐ Conduct 5 user interviews (minimum) with target-population participants
    - For rural audiences: offer phone or video options, not only in-person
    - For lower-digital-literacy: use screen-share with verbal prompts, not written tasks
    - Record and transcribe (Dovetail AI or equivalent)
- ☐ Ask each participant to complete the primary task while thinking aloud

- ☐ Document: where did they hesitate? What confused them? What did they misunderstand?
- ☐ Identify recurring themes (minimum 3 themes that appear in 3+ interviews)

Accessibility Audit

- ☐ Run axe DevTools scan on all pages in scope — document total issues found
- ☐ Categorize: Critical / Serious / Moderate / Minor
- ☐ Manual keyboard test: Tab through entire flow — document where focus is lost or trapped
- ☐ Manual screen reader test (VoiceOver on Mac, NVDA on Windows): document where content is confusing or missing
- ☐ Check color contrast on all text elements (WebAIM Contrast Checker)
- ☐ Count total accessibility issues: ____

Root-Cause Classification

For each identified problem, classify using the SBDAGF taxonomy:

- ☐ **Clarity issues** — User doesn't understand what to do or what something means
- ☐ **Trust issues** — User doesn't believe the process is safe, fair, or honest
- ☐ **Friction issues** — Too many steps, too much effort, too slow
- ☐ **Accessibility issues** — User physically cannot perceive or operate the interface
- ☐ **Value issues** — User doesn't see why they should proceed or pay
- ☐ **Dark patterns** — Interface manipulates user against their interest (pre-selections, hidden costs)

Phase 1 Deliverable

- ☐ Written diagnosis document containing:
    - Funnel map with drop-off percentages
    - Top 3-5 prioritized problems (ranked by impact × feasibility)
    - User quotes illustrating each problem
    - Accessibility issue count and severity breakdown
    - Recommended intervention points

Phase 2: Accessibility-First Design (Week 2–3)

Design System Setup

- ☐ Define color palette — ALL pairings validated at 4.5:1 contrast minimum
- ☐ Define typography scale:
    - Body: minimum 16px, line-height 1.5
    - Headings: logical hierarchy (H1 > H2 > H3), no skipped levels
    - Maximum line length: 80 characters
- ☐ Define spacing system (8px grid recommended)
- ☐ Define interactive states for ALL components:
    - Default, Hover, Focus (high-contrast visible ring), Active, Disabled, Error
- ☐ Define touch targets: minimum 44×44px for all interactive elements
- ☐ Build or select accessible component library in Figma

Wireframing with WCAG Constraints

- ☐ One H1 per page — describes the page purpose
- ☐ Landmark regions defined: header, nav, main, aside (if needed), footer
- ☐ Skip navigation link as first focusable element
- ☐ Focus order annotated (tab sequence matches visual reading order)
- ☐ Form fields have:
    - Visible label (not placeholder-only)
    - Help text where needed
    - Error state with text-based message (not color alone)
    - Required fields marked with text, not just asterisk
- ☐ Links have descriptive text (no "click here" or "read more")
- ☐ Images annotated with alt text intent (meaningful alt vs. decorative empty alt)
- ☐ Modals/overlays have:
    - Focus trap within modal
    - Escape key closes
    - Focus returns to trigger on close
- ☐ Page language specified in document

Hypothesis-Driven Solution Design

For each prioritized problem from Phase 1:

- ☐ Write hypothesis: "If we [specific change], then [user behavior] will [measurable improvement], because [evidence-based reason]."
- ☐ Design minimum 2 variants for experiments + 1 control (current state)

- ☐ Ensure ALL variants meet full WCAG 2.1 Level AA compliance
- ☐ Use Figma Make or other tool for rapid variant generation where applicable
- ☐ Priority rank solutions: Impact × Feasibility × Compliance Value

Cognitive Accessibility Layer

Beyond technical WCAG compliance, apply the SBDAGF cognitive accessibility standards:

- ☐ Plain language (aim for 8th grade reading level — use Hemingway Editor to check)
- ☐ One primary action per screen (reduce decision paralysis)
- ☐ Progressive disclosure (show only what's needed now, reveal complexity gradually)
- ☐ Transparent pricing (no hidden costs, no surprise fees, cumulative total visible)
- ☐ Explicit confirmation before irreversible actions
- ☐ Clear "way out" — user can always go back or exit without penalty
- ☐ Social proof where appropriate (testimonials, review counts, trust badges)
- ☐ Estimated time/effort for multi-step processes (progress indicators)

Phase 2 Deliverable

- ☐ Annotated wireframes/prototypes in Figma with:
    - WCAG annotations on every interactive element
    - Focus order numbered
    - Alt text specified
    - Hypothesis labeled per variant
- ☐ Accessibility specification document (component-level)
- ☐ Design rationale document (why each decision was made, linked to evidence)

Phase 3: Prototype and Validate (Week 3–4)

Prototype Creation

Choose approach based on engagement scope:

Option A — Figma Prototype or in other tool (for testing only):

- ☐ Build clickable prototype in Figma etc.
- ☐ Ensure prototype reflects actual interaction patterns (not just static screens)
- ☐ Test internally: can you complete the primary task via keyboard only?

Option B — Functional AI Prototype (for testing + potential implementation):

- [ ] Build in Lovable from design specification
- [ ] Verify: functional prototype maintains WCAG compliance from design spec
- [ ] Run axe DevTools on live prototype — zero Critical/Serious issues
- [ ] Test: complete primary task via keyboard only in live prototype

Option C — Code Prototype (for complex interactions):

- [ ] Build in Cursor or Claude Design from design specification
- [ ] Run axe DevTools — zero Critical/Serious issues
- [ ] Verify keyboard operability and screen reader compatibility

Usability Testing

- [ ] Recruit 5-8 participants from target population (respondents available in tools like Maze)
    - Must include: at minimum 1 participant with a disability
    - Must include: participants matching digital literacy level of target audience
    - For rural audiences: accommodate remote participation via phone/video
- [ ] Write task scenarios (3-5 tasks covering primary user goals)
- [ ] Set up unmoderated test in Maze (or moderated sessions if population requires)
- [ ] Run test sessions
- [ ] Collect metrics per task:
    - Task completion rate: ____%
    - Average time on task: ____ seconds
    - Error rate: ____%
    - Satisfaction (single ease question or UMUX-Lite): ____
- [ ] Compare results: Variant A vs. Variant B vs. Control
- [ ] Document: which variant wins on each metric?
- [ ] Identify any new usability issues discovered during testing

Iteration (if needed)

- [ ] If no variant beats control: revisit hypothesis, generate new solutions
- [ ] If variant wins but has usability issues: refine and re-test (max 2 iteration cycles)
- [ ] Document learnings even from failed hypotheses (they inform the pattern library)

Phase 3 Deliverable

- [ ] Test results report:
    - Metrics comparison table (control vs. variants)
    - Winning variant identified with confidence level
    - User quotes supporting the decision

    - New issues to address in next iteration
- ☐ Final validated design (the winning variant, refined based on test insights)

Phase 4: Final Compliance Verification (Week 4–5)

Automated Testing

- ☐ Run axe DevTools full scan on final design/prototype
- ☐ Result: 0 Critical issues
- ☐ Result: 0 Serious issues
- ☐ Moderate/Minor issues documented with remediation notes

Manual Testing

- ☐ Keyboard-only navigation: complete all primary tasks without mouse
    - All interactive elements reachable via Tab
    - Focus order matches visual order
    - No focus traps
    - Skip nav works
    - Modals trap focus correctly
- ☐ Screen reader test (VoiceOver or NVDA):
    - All images have appropriate alt text
    - Form labels read correctly
    - Headings structure navigable
    - Link text meaningful out of context
    - Error messages announced
    - Dynamic content changes announced (live regions)
- ☐ Zoom test: page at 200% zoom — no content lost, no horizontal scroll
- ☐ Reflow test: browser at 320px width — all content accessible
- ☐ Motion: any animations respect prefers-reduced-motion
- ☐ Color: remove color (greyscale test) — all information still conveyed

Compliance Documentation

- ☐ Generate WCAG 2.1 Level AA conformance statement
- ☐ Document any known limitations (with remediation timeline)
- ☐ Create accessibility statement for client's website (template provided)

Phase 4 Deliverable

- [ ] Signed-off accessibility conformance report
- [ ] Accessibility statement ready for website footer
- [ ] All issues documented with severity and remediation status

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Phase 5: Implementation Handoff (Week 5–6)

For AI-Platform Implementation (Layer 2)

- [ ] Prepare design specification in format consumable by AI platform:
    - Figma file with auto-layout and design tokens
    - Written description of each component's behavior
    - Content document with all copy finalized
- [ ] Guide client (or implement yourself) through AI platform workflow:
    - Open Lovable / v0 / Bolt.new / Framer
    - Input design specification or description
    - Verify output maintains accessibility compliance
    - Run axe DevTools on generated output
    - Customize content (business-specific text, images, branding)
    - Deploy
- [ ] Post-deployment axe DevTools verification — zero Critical/Serious issues on live site

For Developer Handoff (traditional)

- [ ] Design spec document with:
    - Component specifications (spacing, colors, typography — all accessible values)
    - Interaction specifications (focus management, keyboard behavior, ARIA requirements)
    - Responsive behavior specifications
    - Accessibility annotations on every screen
- [ ] Developer briefing: walk through WCAG requirements for each component
- [ ] QA checklist for developer to self-verify before handoff back to designer

Client Training

- [ ] Train client on:
    - How to add content without breaking accessibility (alt text for images, heading structure)
    - What NOT to change (color contrast values, focus styles, component structure)

- How to run a basic axe DevTools check themselves
- When to contact practitioner for help (structural changes, new pages, new features)

Phase 5 Deliverable

- [ ] Deployed, live, WCAG 2.1 Level AA compliant digital product
- [ ] Client trained on content maintenance
- [ ] Technical documentation archived

Phase 6: Measurement and Case Study (Week 6–8)

Post-Launch Measurement

Wait minimum 2 weeks after launch for data to stabilize, then measure:

- [ ] Conversion rate (post): ____% | Change from baseline: +/- ____%
- [ ] Task completion time (post): ____ sec | Change: +/- ____ sec
- [ ] Bounce rate (post): ____% | Change: +/- ____%
- [ ] UMUX-Lite score (post): ____/100 | Change: +/- ____
- [ ] Accessibility issues (post): ____ | Change from baseline: -____
- [ ] Revenue impact (if measurable): $____ | Change: +/- $____

Calculate ROI

- [ ] Cost of engagement: $____
- [ ] Revenue increase attributed: $____
- [ ] Compliance risk avoided: $____ (estimated penalty exposure eliminated)
- [ ] ROI: ____x return

Case Study Documentation

- [ ] Write case study following SBDAGF template:
    - Business context (type, location, audience)
    - Problem diagnosed (with metrics)
    - Solution designed (with methodology applied)
    - Results measured (before/after)
    - Accessibility compliance achieved
    - AI tools used and their contribution
- [ ] Client approval for publication (or anonymize)

- [ ] Publish to SBDAGF evidence base
- [ ] Extract reusable patterns for open-source library contribution

Phase 6 Deliverable

- [ ] Before/after metrics report for client
- [ ] Published case study (SBDAGF evidence base)
- [ ] Validated patterns contributed to open-source library
- [ ] Client testimonial (if provided)

Quick-Reference: SBDAGF Decision Framework

When you're stuck on a design decision, use this:

Question	**Framework**
"Is this accessible?"	Run axe DevTools + keyboard test. Binary: pass or fail.
"Which variant is better?"	Test with users. Don't guess. Data decides.
"Should we add this feature?"	Does it serve the primary user task? If no, cut it.
"Who decides this?"	UX trade-offs: you. Business priority: owner. Technical: platform. Metric: data.
"Is the copy clear enough?"	Hemingway Editor: 8th grade or below. If not, simplify.
"Is this a dark pattern?"	Would the user choose this if they fully understood? If no, remove it.
"Should we ship this?"	Has it been tested with users AND passed accessibility verification? Both required.

Quick-Reference: When to Use Which AI Tool

Task	Tool	Why
Generate UI component variants quickly	Figma Make	Speed. Multiple options in minutes.
Build functional clickable prototype	Lovable	No code. Testable. Deployable.
Build high-fidelity coded prototype	Cursor	Production-quality. Full control.
Run unmoderated usability test	Maze	Scalable. Quantitative + qualitative.
Automated accessibility scan	axe DevTools	Industry standard. Zero false positives.
Synthesize research transcripts	Dovetail AI	Pattern recognition across interviews.
Deploy a live small-business website	Lovable / Framer / Vercel	One-click deploy. Hosting included.

Quality Gates: Do Not Proceed If...

Do NOT proceed from Phase 1 → Phase 2 if:

- You have fewer than 5 user data points (interviews or analytics observations)
- You cannot articulate the #1 problem in one sentence
- You don't have a baseline metric to beat

Do NOT proceed from Phase 2 → Phase 3 if:

- Any component in your design fails WCAG contrast requirements
- You haven't specified focus order and keyboard behavior
- Your hypothesis is not written as a testable statement

Do NOT proceed from Phase 3 → Phase 4 if:

- No variant outperformed the control (go back and redesign)
- You tested with fewer than 5 participants
- You didn't include any participants from the target population

Do NOT proceed from Phase 4 → Phase 5 if:

- axe DevTools reports any Critical or Serious issues
- Keyboard-only navigation cannot complete the primary task
- Screen reader test reveals content that is invisible or confusing

Do NOT proceed from Phase 5 → Phase 6 if:

- Live deployed site has not been verified with axe DevTools
- Client has not been trained on accessible content maintenance

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Engagement Completion Checklist

Before closing an SBDAGF engagement, confirm:

- [ ] Client has a live, deployed, WCAG 2.1 Level AA compliant digital product
- [ ] Before/after metrics documented (conversion rate change, at minimum)
- [ ] Accessibility conformance verified and documented
- [ ] Client trained on maintenance
- [ ] Case study written (or in progress)
- [ ] Reusable patterns identified for open-source library
- [ ] Client knows how to reach you for future phases

Continuing Education

Report issues or suggest improvements: [email: elzbieta.bojarczuk2@gmail.com]

This checklist is a living document updated based on practitioner feedback and new research. Version history and changelog available at [URL].

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